
Elon Musk's Biggest Twitter Nemesis Is an 87-Year-Old Pulitzer Prize Finalist

Published by

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Estimated reading time

6 min

Added on

2025-11-14

Address

<https://slate.com/technology/2025/11/elon-musk-joyce-carol-oates-twitter-nemesis.html>

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Did you know that Elon Musk *reads books*? And has, in fact, read *many* books? And has watched movies? And enjoys things? That is what Tesla's CEO—who has just been promised \$1 trillion of stock compensation over the next 10 years should he manage to [reinvigorate car sales](#) and [build an army of 1 million robots](#)—has been hoping to impress upon X users over the past week.

On Monday: "[Man on Fire is great!](#)" Sunday: "[Fifth Element has great style.](#)" The Thursday before that, more detailed praise of 1997's *The Fifth Element*: "[Great movie.](#)" Meanwhile, [X boosted a promoted post from the book-summarizing app Blinkist](#) insisting that "Elon reads a lot" and suggesting "9 nonfiction books" he has recommended.

One author he will not promote, however? The 87-year-old Pulitzer finalist and Twitter legend Joyce Carol Oates, whose "laboriously pretentious drivel" would be less enjoyable than "[eating a bag of sawdust](#)," per the world's wealthiest man.

Why launch this stray at the woman who gave us [We Were the Mulvaney](#)s and [Blonde](#), among dozens of other classics—including a [handful of poems](#) for Slate? Well, one thing many people have long known about Oates, even if they've never read her award-winning short stories, is that she [loves to tweet, a lot](#), in a [rather outrageous manner](#). This [has continued](#) well into the Musk era of X-née-Twitter, with the [liberal Oates occasionally directing](#) her snipes and barbs at the platform's [white nationalist owner](#).

In this most recent instance, JCO offered some thoughts after Texas state Sen. Roland Gutierrez [kicked off a beef](#) with Musk by [posting a video](#) outside Tesla's Austin Gigafactory, where he referred to Musk as a "greedy hog" for taking the trillion-dollar stock agreement, along with countless federal subsidies, while everyday Americans were losing their SNAP benefits. Musk responded with rage, clarifying that he would not earn the trillion dollars if he failed to meet investor demands and denigrating the lawmaker as "a taker, not a maker. All you've done your whole life is take from the makers of the world."

Musk fans naturally loved that, with one conservative writer approvingly sharing a screenshot. It was at this point that Oates entered the picture, quote-tweeting the post with [an extended observation](#).

So curious that such a wealthy man never posts anything that indicates that he enjoys or is even aware of what virtually everyone appreciates—scenes from nature, pet dog or cat, praise for a movie, music, a book (but doubt that he reads); pride in a friend's or relative's accomplishment; condolences for someone who has died; pleasure in sports, acclaim for a favorite team; references to history. In fact he seems totally uneducated, uncultured. The poorest persons on Twitter may have access to more beauty & meaning in life than the "most wealthy person in the world."

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— Joyce Carol Oates (@JoyceCarolOates)
[November 8, 2025](#)

This obviously got some attention from the liberals on X, [one of whom](#) told her to “pinch his wretched little dick off you icon.” But it also drew complaints from the most sycophantic Musk stans, who will always volunteer their time to defend him. [Sharing screenshots](#) of the tweet—presumably to avoid JCO's wrath—various Tesla investors ran interference and accused Oates of “[dehumanizing](#)” their king, to his vocal gratitude. “Everything she says in her post about me can be shown to be demonstrably false with a simple search,” Musk whined in one reply. “Oates is a lazy liar and ... an abuser of semicolons!”

The aforementioned “bag of sawdust” post came in response to a [screenshot of older tweets](#) in which Musk had praised Iain M. Banks' *The Culture*—including one reply to Cory Doctorow in which Musk posited that Banks “certainly wasn't pro-union in the Culture books. At all. And wouldn't be in the case of Tesla.”

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Now, here's the thing: Anyone who's actually read Banks and the *Culture* books knows well that the late Scottish author was an [avowed leftist](#) who [loathed oligarchs](#) and repeatedly described the setting of his best-known series as a “[socialist](#)” or “[communist](#)” [utopia](#) whose citizens [transcend the gender binary](#). So, pretty distant from Musk's [transphobia](#) and far-right techno-centrism. Not that this is the only time Musk has clearly misunderstood a book he claims to love: As I wrote two years ago, his assertion that he based X's lewd A.I. chatbot on *The Hitchhiker's Guide to the Galaxy* [betrayed a complete misunderstanding of the iconic series](#) and of author Douglas Adams' animating philosophy.

Joyce Carol Oates, for her part, had spent much of her post-diss free time ignoring Musk and actually discussing literature with other readers [at the Charleston Literary Festival](#). But like any true poster, she couldn't stay away for long. The day after the festival, Oates refocused on the hurt Tesla CEO, resharing an [anti-Musk newsletter](#) from Robert Reich and responding to a fan of her Musk insult [with an explanation](#): "Truly it was out of curiosity: why a person with unlimited resources exhibits so little appreciation or even awareness of the things that most people value as giving meaning to life." It didn't stop Musk lovers from swarming her replies. So the prolific octogenarian doubled down, [retweeting other](#) Tesla and Musk haters [and praising](#) the mogul's estranged transgender daughter. ("She is impressive! A normal parent would be very proud.")

It should be noted that this isn't the first time Musk has been compelled to interact with Oates: After last year's election, when JCO decried Republicans' anti-trans campaign ads, the devoted transphobe J.K. Rowling sneered at Oates' concern, while Musk referred to the author as "[a bit of an extinctionist](#)."

If you'd been on Twitter in the early days, this all might strike you as a completely bonkers development. Not long ago, it was Oates who was the far more notorious tweeter, having racked up a series of [Islamophobic](#), [racist](#), [classist](#), and [simply out-of-touch posts](#) that earned her [widespread notoriety](#) within the literary world. (There was also that time she randomly posted a [gross picture of her blistering foot](#).) JCO was chided often, and rightly, for all those tweets, the output of an old-school white liberal whose understandings of social justice and liberalism certainly predated the Obama-era internet's. Even more wildly, this was at a time when Elon Musk was the far more normal tweeter, who chose to avoid wading into politics [after getting yelled at for praising Margaret Thatcher](#) in the wake of her death.

How things have turned. Now Oates is the one ragging on Musk for his [anti-empathy stance](#), [citing the great Denis Johnson](#) in her attempt to try to understand the tech billionaire, and all but [calling him a loser](#) while lauding [Musk enemy Zohran Mamdani](#). The feud has become a [trending topic on X](#), summarized by its A.I. bots. And Musk fans are [pointing to his *Fifth Element* tweets](#) to defend him. To [paraphrase Iain Banks himself](#), reality makes a lot less sense than fiction these days.

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